

“Playing the Game”: Influence Checks in *Moonsea Rising*

“Playing the game” in the Moonsea Empire starts with the normal methods of social interactions: using Charisma skills like Persuasion or Intimidation to push an NPC to do a favor; Intelligence skills like Investigation or History to learn or recall important facts and details that an NPC might possess; or Wisdom skills like Insight and Perception to notice an NPC’s reactions or behaviors to discern what he or she might be thinking or feeling.

Improving an NPC’s attitude is another effective use of skills during a social interaction. Every NPC starts off with an attitude toward the PCs that is either Friendly, Indifferent, or Hostile. This attitude impacts the DC of various skill checks needed to influence the NPC. Generally, a PC needs to achieve at least two and sometimes more successes in order to move an NPC from Hostile to Indifferent or Indifferent to Friendly.

My game will introduce two new tools for use during social interactions: ***Influence an Area***, and ***Influence an NPC***. Each is slightly different, but they work together and affect each other. These new tools can and should be used to achieve special rewards that go beyond the normal D&D standard Intimidate or Persuasion Checks.

The point of having a structured system is so that we can enjoy a game that features lots of social interaction, but still use the system of skills and abilities that make playing D&D 5e so much fun. Also, in my experience, this levels the playing field a bit for players who are not naturally outgoing or extroverted. D&D players who want to play strong characters don’t have to have big muscles, so why should players who want to play clever, influential characters have to be charismatic charmers in order to convince the DM to reward their creativity?

Of course, this system gamifies the delivery straightforward rewards, like additional XP, items, treasure, and improving NPC attitudes towards the party. But these tools are also designed to unlock an additional set of special rewards, as well. By far the most important rewards will be story-based: a merchant offers the party a discount on future purchases; a city guard decides to let you slip away the next time you get caught in a minor crime; or a powerful baron agrees to introduce you to one of his political allies. In addition, these story rewards can often include otherwise inaccessible information, such as an NPC’s inner thoughts, plans they he may be privy to, or secrets he is supposed to be safeguarding.

Social Rounds

There will be vastly more social interaction than combat in this campaign. In order to provide some structure, the DM will occasionally declare that the PCs have a certain number of “social rounds” to accomplish whatever they want. The DM will define the in-game duration of the rounds (often 20 minutes or so) and how many the PCs get.

For example, let’s say the PCs have been invited to a party. The DM might declare the the PCs have one hour to mingle with the other guests before the host calls their seats for dinner and that the time will be divided into three social rounds. Since we have three rounds in an hour, each social round will last about 20 minutes of time in the game.

In reality, the players will take turns that last only a minute or two, with each player describing or roleplaying their social interaction. It is up to the players whether they act out the interaction (with the DM playing the role of NPCs) or if they merely describe the desired interaction.

Just as with a combat encounter, it often makes sense for the party to use their turns to act strategically. It is a good idea to have a plan, if you know what you want to accomplish and with whom. It is also assumed that the social rounds are long enough and there is enough moving around and mingling that PCs can share information with each other during and between turns and rounds.

I. INFLUENCE AN AREA

PCs may attempt to influence a discrete area such that all of the people gathered there will feel more positively disposed towards you and your party.

An area might be a room you just entered, a tavern where you're drinking, or a gathering of people on a street corner or in the market. In certain specified cases, the area can be an entire village, neighborhood, estate, encampment, or other coherent cluster of humanity, but the larger the area the less likely this is the proper mechanic to use. Indeed, influencing more than just a discrete group of people is a different process - that of building a reputation (more on that when we get to third level!)

The influence action represents your attempt win over the people in this area as a group, instead of one at a time. The rich noble, Aleric buys drinks for the whole tavern. The humble Friar Bob waxes eloquent in front of a gathering of religious scholars. The wise diplomat, Vallana, works the crowd at a dinner party, using flattery and persuasion to create a more favorable impression of her among the guests sitting around the table. The talented knight, Albrecht, wows a crowd of spectators at the jousting grounds with his swordsmanship.

There are as many ways to influence an area as there are actions that can be taken in the presence of others. Each area has a set of skill checks that can be used to achieve influence, and the kind of checks that are appropriate depend entirely on the specifics of that area: who is there, why people are gathered, where they are gathered, etc.

In the sanctuary of a church, for example, the most obvious skill check would be Religion. But if the sanctuary is the resting place of a magical holy artifact, a successful Arcana check might also influence the area. Perhaps the sanctuary is in the Temple of Sylvanus (a nature deity), in which case a successful Nature check would be quite useful.

Each of the checks for a given area have a Difficulty Class (DC) set by the DM. The DC is determined by a number of factors, such as the attitudes of the people in the area, the amount that is generally known about those people and that place, the purpose of the gathering, or the nature of the area. For example, if you are in the shop of a merchant who specializes in rare and exotic magic items, the Arcana DC is likely to be higher than if you are in a random stall at the open market near the docks. Similarly, influencing a room full of jaded nobles who have seen hundreds of bards perform will likely require a higher Perform DC than a group of farmers from a small village, especially if the jaded nobles have paid money to attend a show.

Every time a member of the party achieves a success, the number of points by which the roll exceeds the DC is added to the party's aggregate "influence score" for that area. So, if the DC is 12 and bard rolls a modified 18 on his perform check, the party gets 6 points added to its influence score for that area. Once the influence score for an area passes a particular threshold, the party earns the rewards associated with that threshold. A given area may have multiple thresholds with a series of increasingly valuable rewards.

For example, the sanctuary of the Temple of Sylvanus may have two thresholds, one at 10 points and a second at 20 points. Vallana tries to influence the area with an Animal Handling

Check, and her roll exceeds the DC by 6 points. Next, Friar Bob makes a Religion Check, exceeding the DC by 8. The party's aggregate Influence Score is now 14, which exceeds the first threshold value for the Sanctuary. The DM awards the group 20 XP and tells the party that a particularly talkative priest confides that the temple was built on the site of an old burial ground.

Next, Albrecht attempts to influence the area by making a History Check, exceeding the DC by 6 points. This brings the party's aggregate Influence Score to 20, enough to hit the second threshold. The DM awards an extra 10 XP, and says the talkative priest is so excited to find people as interested in the history of the building as he is that he walks you over to an alcove, where he shows you the original architectural plans. In addition to having detailed plans to the temple, you also find a scroll of clairvoyance among the dusty parchments. The priest is happy to let you keep those, since he figures they were lost long ago and no one will miss them.

Quite often, the rewards for influencing an area will have an impact on future social interactions in the area, such as gathering intelligence, influencing NPCs, and so forth.

II. INFLUENCE AN NPC

You make a skill check attempting to win an NPC's favor. There are two types of checks: a Discovery Check and an Influence check.

Discovery Check

Although some are comfortable going in blind, most skilled practitioners of the arts of diplomacy and intrigue know that the first step toward influencing an NPC is to discover his passions and weaknesses.

Every NPC has a weaknesses and passions that determine which skills can best be used to influence him. The easier an NPC is to manipulate, the more weakness he will have and more skills will be available to influence him. Also, the DCs for those skill checks will be lower for weak characters and higher for strong characters.

Once during a social round, you can make a Discovery Check using a skill that you have convinced the DM is appropriate to the situation. The higher you roll, the more you learn. You might learn about their passions, which will tell you one or more skills that are useful for influencing that character. If you roll really high, you might learn about a weakness, giving you and anyone you share this info a +2 bonus to future attempts to influence that NPC.

You can make additional Discovery Checks in future time periods to uncover additional influence skills for the same NPC or to determine that NPC's weakness.

For example, Bob is playing Alerick, a noble at a party. Bob tells the DM that while his character, Alerick, is conversing with Lady Bristow about her magnificent estate, Alerick will tell her that she seems bored at the party and he bets she would rather be somewhere else right now. He suggests the use of his Deception skill, since he doesn't really think the girl looks bored and this is just a ploy to get her talking. The DM agrees that Deception is an appropriate skill to use.

Lady Bristow is a 12 year-old girl and Bob's roll of 12 is sufficient to allow Alerick to determine that Animal Handling is one of Lady Bristow's influence skills because she is obsessed with horses. The DC check to deceive the little girl is only 10. If Lady Bristow had been a bitter old crone instead of a young girl, the DC for that skill check might have been much higher,

meaning that 12 would not have been a success (perhaps the crone would be wiser and harder to interrogate).

The DM should give you some hints when you have exhausted the avenues for influence so that you don't waste additional time trying doing Discovery Checks to discern possible influence skills that do not exist for that NPC.

If your Discovery Check roll exceeds the DC by 5 or more, you get to learn of the NPC's weakness, giving you a +2 bonus on all future attempts to influence that NPC. You may also share the weakness with others, giving them the same +2 bonus.

For example, let's say Vallana wants to spend her next social round talking with a guard on duty outside of a prison. Vallana is a member of House Kilaudra, and will use her Insight skill to make a Discovery Check to ascertain the guard's passions and/or weaknesses. Vallana rolls a 19. So, they role-play a bit of social interaction and she takes her cues from what the guard says. Or maybe she just describes what her character will want to say and the DM simply tells her how the guard .

With a 19, Vallana gets to learn not only one of the skills she can use to influence the guard, but also one of his weaknesses. The DM tells her she noticed the guard's expression soften when she mentioned the subject of elven rights. Vallana mentions that her family is closely connected to the elves of Hilsfar and that she is on a mission to help the elves. The guard gasps in surprise, and through tearful eyes reveals to Vallana that his family is descended from one of the human abolitionist houses in Hilsfar that worked with Edric Storm to free the elves from slavery. As a result, he is particularly sensitive to mistreatment of elves and full of shame for the anti-elven bigotry expressed by so many of his fellow humans. Thanks to this successful Discovery Check, Vallana now knows that History is an important skill to influence this guard. Plus, she knows that he is particularly ashamed of the way humans treat the elves. So, she and anyone she share this information will gain a +2 bonus on attempts to influence the guard.

Influence Check

You may attempt to use a specific skill to influence an NPC.

If you have made a successful Discovery Check to determine which skill to use or to discover an NPC's weakness (or if another in your party has done so and relayed the information to you) you know which skills give you a chance to successfully influence the NPC and you get a +2 bonus to this roll.

But even if you haven't made a Discovery Check, you can still try to use a skill of your choice to influence the NPC. Perhaps you are talking to a priest and suspect that a Religion Check will get the job done. Go ahead! You just won't know whether the influence check failed (if it fails) because you chose the wrong skill or you didn't roll high enough.

Many NPCs require multiple successes to fully influence them, so even after an initial success, you may be required to make another check in a future social round.

Returning to our horse-loving friend, young Lady Bristow, Bob's character Alerick decides to make an Animal Handling Check, conversing with the girl about his favorite grooming techniques. He rolls high and achieves a success. The DM tells him that the girl is starting to warm to him, but she still seems to be holding back.

In the next social round, Alerick continues the conversation with Lady Bristow, again using Animal Handling while debating with her the proper tightness for the saddle straps to achieve security without hurting the horse. Another success! And now the girl's demeanor changes noticeably. Her eyes light up and she looks around conspiratorially before asking if Alerick has heard the rumor about what really happened in the stables at Ravencroft Manor. Turns out, she was visiting the Ravencrofts when it happened and their son (who was terribly cruel, in case you didn't know) did not die from a mere fall off the horse while taking a regular ride, but rather while whipping the horse and forcing it to walk over a pile of scrap metal. She recalls the family being upset, but she overheard Lord Ravencroft muttering to his wife that they had other sons, of course, and perhaps the family had dodged an arrow. This tidbit grants the party a +2 bonus on all interactions with any of the Ravencrofts, and also nets them 80 XP.